

The classroom laptop

Chromebooks were designed with one primary goal in mind – a world of functionality with the lightweight footprint and ease of use of a web browser that you were already familiar with. While the Chrome OS was announced in 2009, the first commercial Chromebook wasn't on sale until May 2011. During this time, Google had designed and produced prototypes dubbed Cr48. These prototypes were built and distributed to Chrome OS enthusiasts as well as potential developers for the platform, mainly to test the operating system. As Sundar Pichai himself had put it at the launch of Cr-48, "The hardware exists only to test the software."



HP Chromebook

The Chrome project was born out of a need to remove all that was unnecessary on existing machines. Without going into too much detail about the software, it suffices to say that entire thing sparked when the original Chrome OS development team managed to remove unnecessary checks like those for a floppy drive from the system and got a

Linux-based system to boot up in 10 seconds flat on an ageing netbook, and thus the Chrome project was born. And it almost immediately lost out to Android and the mobile in terms of adoption. But more on that later.

Anything that came from Google and did not work – Buzz, Wave and the likes – showed every Google employee one thing, if you're making something at Google, you better make it for everybody. Hence, on top of the usability factor, Google also incorporated affordability into Chromebooks. Leaving it upto the OEMs saw the rise of many cheap, affordable Chromebook options over the year. And the one place where a lightweight, no-nonsense cheap device did make sense was the classroom.

Google's focus on collaboration, and the fact that the Google Classroom worked pretty well on Chromebooks, made them a popular hit with schools. By January 2012, even while commercial sales were flat, Google placed nearly 27,000 Chromebooks in schools across 41 states in the US, including "one-on-one" programs, which allocate a computer for every student in South Carolina, Illinois, and Iowa. As of August 2012, over 500 school districts in the United States and Europe were using the device. In 2016, Chromebooks